

Word family: **when / whenever**

Base word: when

Closely related form: whenever

Part of speech: conjunction (連接詞) / interrogative adverb (疑問副詞) / relative adverb (關係副詞)

Useful expressions: when?, when + clause, whenever, since when?, when it comes to..., the whens and wheres

Your sentence:

> “I still use them now, especially **when** I am travelling or trying to focus.”

A semantic note first: **when has several important grammatical uses, but most of them grow from one strong core concept: “at/during the time or situation in which something happens.”** We should therefore distinguish the useful functions without pretending they are completely unrelated lexical meanings.

Meaning in this passage

Here, **when** means:

during the times or situations in which I am travelling or trying to concentrate.

繁體中文 : ** **當.....的時候 ; 在.....這種情況下

Natural translation:

> “I still use them now, especially when I am travelling or trying to focus.”

「我現在仍然會使用它們 , **尤其是在旅行或想集中精神的時候**。」

Here:

when + clause = 當某件事情正在發生 / 某種情況成立的時候

1. **when + clause (時間 / 情況) — 當.....的時候 ; 在.....時**

This is your original meaning.

Meaning: At or during the time that something happens or is true.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I use the headphones **when I am travelling**.”

「我**旅行的時候**會使用這副耳機。」

Practice 2

> “Call me **when you arrive**.”

「你**到達時**打電話給我。」

Practice 3

> “I listen to music **when I work**.”

「我**工作的時候**會聽音樂。」

when + clause = 某件事情發生或某個狀態成立的時間

2. **when = at what time? (詢問時間) — 甚麼時候 ; 何時**

Here, **when** introduces a question.

Practice 4

> “**When** did you buy the headphones?”

「你**甚麼時候**買這副耳機的？」

Practice 5

> “**When** will the meeting start?”

「會議**甚麼時候**開始？」

when? = 詢問某件事情發生、開始或結束的時間

3. **when + subject + verb (間接問題) — 何時 ; 甚麼時候**

The question can be embedded inside another sentence.

Practice 6

> “I don’t know **when the train will arrive**.”

「我不知道火車**甚麼時候會到**。」

Practice 7

> “Can you tell me **when the shop closes**?”

「你可以告訴我商店**甚麼時候關門**嗎？」

****when + clause — indirect question = 詢問或談論某件事情發生的時間，但整個 when-clause 放在另一個句子之中****

Important word order:

> “When **will the train arrive**?”  direct question

but:

> “I don’t know when **the train will arrive**.”  indirect question

Not:

> *I don’t know when will the train arrive.* 

4. ****when = the time at which (關係用法) —的時候；之時****

****When** can connect a particular time or period to what happened then.**

Practice 8

> “I remember the day **when we first met**.”

「我記得我們**第一次見面的那一天**。」

Practice 9

> “There was a time **when people rarely worked from home**.”

「曾經有一段時期，**那時人們很少在家工作**。」

****when = 指回前面所提到的時間、日期、年代或時期，說明在那個時候發生甚麼****

Common nouns before **when** include:

- * time
- * day
- * year
- * moment
- * period
- * occasion

5. **when** = whenever a repeated situation occurs (每當.....時) — 每當 ; —.....就常常.....

Sometimes **when** refers not to one particular occasion but to something that happens repeatedly.

Practice 10

> “I wear headphones **when** I travel.”

「我**每當旅行時**都會戴耳機。」

Practice 11

> “She gets nervous **when** she speaks in public.”

「她**每當公開演講時**都會緊張。」

when — habitual = 每次某個情況發生時 , 另一件事情通常也會發生

This is actually relevant to your sentence.

> “especially when I am travelling”

can mean not just **one particular trip**, but generally:

「尤其是每當我旅行的時候」

6. **when** = after/once something happens (先後關係) — 當.....之後 ;時就

Depending on context, **when** can imply that one event follows another.

Practice 12

> “I’ll call you **when I finish**.”

「我**完成之後 / 完成時**會打電話給你。」

Practice 13

> “We’ll leave **when everyone is ready**.”

「**大家都準備好之後**，我們就出發。」

when = 以某件事情的發生作為另一件事情開始的時間點

Chinese often naturally uses:

等……之後 / ……時就……

7. **when = although/considering that (對比) — 既然 / 明明……卻……**

This is a less obvious but useful meaning.

Meaning: Used to show that one fact makes another fact surprising or unreasonable.

Practice 14

> “Why buy a new phone **when** your old one still works perfectly?”

「你的舊電話**明明還運作得很好，為甚麼**還要買新的？」

Practice 15

> “There’s no reason to drive **when** the station is so close.”

「車站**既然這麼近**，根本沒有必要開車。」

when — contrast/reason = 提出一個已有的事實，表示在這種情況下，另一個行動似乎沒有必要或令人意外

This is genuinely different from simple chronological 「當……時」.

8. **whenever = every time that (反覆情況) — 每當；每次……都**

****Whenever**** makes the repeated meaning explicit.

Practice 16

> “I use noise cancellation ****whenever I travel****.”

「我****每次旅行時****都會使用降噪功能。」

Practice 17

> “Call me ****whenever you need help****.”

「你****每當需要幫忙時****都可以打電話給我。」

****whenever = 每一次某個情況出現時，不限於某一次****

Compare:

> ****when I travel****

> = 當我旅行時；可指某次或一般情況

> ****whenever I travel****

> = ****每當我旅行時****；明確表示每一次

9. ****whenever = at any time that (任何時候) — 無論何時；隨時****

Practice 18

> “You can visit ****whenever you like****.”

「你****任何時候想來都可以 / 隨時可以來****。」

Practice 19

> “Use the headphones ****whenever you need some quiet****.”

「你****任何時候需要安靜一下****，都可以使用這副耳機。」

****whenever = 不限制具體時間；任何符合條件的時候都可以****

So ****whenever**** has two closely related readings:

* ****every time**** → 每當

* ****any time**** → 無論何時 / 隨時

10. **whenever? (對時間感到驚訝 / 追問) — 到底甚麼時候? **

In conversational English, **whenever** can sometimes intensify **when**, particularly in varieties such as British/Irish English.

Practice 20

> “**Whenever** did you find time to do all that?”

「你**到底甚麼時候**有時間做完這些事情的？」

Practice 21

> “Whenever did he learn to cook like that?”

「他**到底甚麼時候**學會煮得這麼好的？」

whenever — question = 帶驚訝或強調地追問「到底甚麼時候」

This is less universal than ordinary **when**, so it is useful to recognize rather than prioritize for production.

11. **since when? — 從甚麼時候開始? ; 甚麼時候開始變成這樣? **

A very common fixed expression.

It can be a genuine time question:

> “**Since when** have you worked here?”

「你**從甚麼時候開始**在這裡工作的？」

But it very often expresses **surprise or challenge**:

> “**Since when** do you like coffee?”

「你**甚麼時候開始喜歡咖啡的? **」

The implication may be:

> “I thought you didn’t like coffee.”

Another example:

> “**Since when** are you an expert?”

「你**甚麼時候變成專家了？**」

This can sound sarcastic.

since when = 詢問某個情況從何時開始；亦常帶有驚訝、質疑甚至諷刺意味

12. **when it comes to + topic/activity (話題 / 事情) — 說到.....；談到.....方面**

A very useful fixed expression.

Practice 22

> “**When it comes to** comfort, these headphones are excellent.”

「**說到舒適度方面**，這副耳機非常出色。」

Practice 23

> “She is very careful **when it comes to** money.”

「**說到金錢方面**，她非常謹慎。」

when it comes to something = 說到某個特定話題、範疇或事情時

This is not literally asking about time.

13. **the whens and wheres = details of when and where something will happen — 時間和地點等具體安排**

Here, **when** behaves like a noun inside a fixed expression.

Practice 24

> “We’ve agreed on the plan, but not the **whens and wheres**.”

「我們已經同意整體計劃，但**具體時間和地點等安排**還沒有決定。」

Practice 25

> “Let’s discuss the **whens and wheres** tomorrow.”

「我們明天再討論**具體的時間和地點安排**。」

the whens and wheres = 某件事何時、何地進行等具體細節

This is informal and much less central than ordinary **when**, but worth recognizing.

Important distinction: **when vs while**

This is extremely useful.

when

can refer to:

- * a moment
- * an event
- * a period
- * repeated situations

> “Call me **when you arrive**.”

「你到達時打給我。」

while

emphasizes **during the period that something is continuing**

> “I listened to music **while I was travelling**.”

「我旅行途中一直聽音樂。」

Compare:

> “I dropped my phone **when I got off the train**.”

= 在下車那一刻

> “I listened to music **while I was on the train**.”

= 在乘車的一段時間內

Important distinction: **when vs if**

This one is crucial.

when

usually suggests that the event **will happen / normally happens**

> “I’ll call you **when I arrive**.”

「我到達時會打給你。」

The speaker expects to arrive.

if

means the event is a **condition and may or may not happen**

> “I’ll call you **if I arrive early**.”

「如果我早到，我會打給你。」

Maybe the speaker will arrive early; maybe not.

So:

when = 當.....時 (預期會發生)

if = 如果..... (是否發生不確定)

Important distinction: **when vs whenever**

when

can refer to one particular time or a general repeated situation.

> “Call me when you arrive.”

「你到達時打給我。」

whenever

explicitly means every time or any time.

> “Call me whenever you need help.”

「任何時候需要幫忙都可以打給我。」

Important distinction: **when** vs **what time**

Both can ask about time.

when

can request a broad answer:

> “When are you leaving?”

Possible answer:

> “Tomorrow.”

what time

usually asks specifically for a clock time:

> “What time are you leaving?”

Possible answer:

> “At 7:30.”

So:

when = 何時，可以是日期、日子、時段或時間

what time = 幾點，通常要求具體鐘點

Important future-tense grammar: **when** + present, not usually **will**

After **when** referring to the future, English normally uses the **present tense** in the **when**-clause.

> “I’ll call you **when** I arrive.” ✓

Not normally:

> “I’ll call you **when I will arrive**.” ❌

Likewise:

> “When the meeting **ends**, we’ll go home.” ✅

even though the meeting ending is in the future.

However, **will** can appear after **when** when **when** introduces an indirect question:

> “I don’t know **when he will arrive**.” ✅

Why?

Because this means:

I don't know the answer to the question “When will he arrive?”

So compare carefully:

Time clause

> “I’ll leave **when he arrives**.”

「他到達時我就離開。」

Indirect question

> “I don’t know **when he will arrive**.”

「我不知道他甚麼時候會到。」

This is an excellent grammar distinction.

Important distinction in your exact sentence: **when** vs **while**

Your sentence says:

> “especially **when I am travelling**”

You could also say:

> “especially **while I am travelling**”

But there is a small difference.

when I am travelling

= **在我旅行這種情況 / 時候**

It presents travelling as a **situation in which the headphones are especially useful**.

while I am travelling

= **在我正在旅行的那段期間**

It emphasizes the **duration** more strongly.

For your sentence, **when** is very natural because you're describing the situations in which you tend to use the headphones.

Family-extension sweep

The **when** family itself is small. The useful material comes mostly from grammatical patterns and fixed expressions:

* **when + clause** = 當.....時

* **when?** = 甚麼時候？

* **when — indirect question** = 何時

* **when — relative** =的時候

* **when — habitual** = 每當

* **when — contrast/reason** = 既然 / 明明.....卻.....

* **whenever — every time** = 每當

* **whenever — any time** = 無論何時 / 隨時

* **since when?** = 從甚麼時候開始？ / 甚麼時候變成這樣？

* **when it comes to...** = 說到.....方面

* **the whens and wheres** = 時間、地點等具體安排

There are archaic relatives such as **whence**, but they do **not** belong in our normal modern learner set just because they look historically related. Under our Golden Manual, I would exclude them unless the context specifically requires them.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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when + clause — time	某件事情發生或某種狀態成立的時候
when?	詢問某件事情發生、開始或結束的時間
when — indirect question	在另一句子中詢問或談論某件事情發生的時間
when — relative	指回前面提到的日期、時期或時刻，說明當時發生的事情
when — habitual	每次某個情況發生時，另一件事情通常也會發生
when — sequence	以某件事情的發生作為另一行動開始的時間點
when — contrast/reason	提出已有事實，表示在這種情況下另一行動似乎不必要或令人意外
whenever — every time	每一次某種情況出現時
whenever — any time	任何符合條件的時候；不限制具體時間
since when?	詢問某個情況從何時開始；亦可帶驚訝或質疑
when it comes to...	說到某個特定話題、範疇或事情時
the whens and wheres	某件事何時、何地進行等具體安排

For your original sentence

> “I still use them now, especially ****when I am travelling or trying to focus****.”

The exact meaning is:

****when = 在旅行或試圖集中精神這些情況 / 時候出現時****

And because the sentence describes the speaker’s ****general habit****, there is also a slight repeated meaning:

> ****especially whenever I am travelling or trying to focus****

≈ ****尤其是每當我旅行或想集中精神的時候****

The most natural translation remains:

> ****「我現在仍然會使用它們，尤其是在旅行或想集中精神的時候。」****